

equipped as gunships; reconnaissance aircraft fitted with the latest electronic and infrared detection devices; and the many hundreds of land- and carrier-based fighter and strike aircraft that took the war to North Vietnam. But despite the skill and bravery of US aircrews and the technological ingenuity shown in adapting to the specific demands of the conflict, it remained the wrong war for American air forces to be fighting, with the wrong kind of enemy and the wrong kind of rules.

The problem of Vietnam, as it presented itself to America's political leaders, was how to prevent a communist takeover in South Vietnam without escalating the conflict into a confrontation with China or the Soviet Union. It was decided that North Vietnam, whose communist leaders were regarded as in control of the guerrillas in the South, could not be invaded but could, within limits, be bombed. Bombing the North was extremely attractive politically because it would minimize American casualties and was relatively easy to control – the heat could be turned up or down by political decision-makers. But the desire to avoid escalation meant that the unbridled destruction of targets in and around North Vietnam's main cities was ruled out. Under these circumstances, strategic air power had no chance of deterring a determined enemy. From 1965, the United States was forced to commit massive ground forces to

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LIEUTENANT GENERAL BERNARD W. ROGERS
DESCRIBING OPERATION CEDAR FALLS, 1967

South Vietnam, supported by tactical air power on an unprecedented scale.

Numbers of American airmen had already been involved in the conflict in South Vietnam since the early 1960s. For example, American helicopter pilots accompanied South Vietnamese troops into combat and American crews flew transport aircraft loaded with Agent Orange, defoliating large tracts of the countryside in order to deny shelter to the guerrilla forces. Once the US Army and Marines went in to take over the main combat role from the South Vietnamese, aircraft became central to their commanders' strategy for defeating the guerrillas. Their thinking centered on the twin concepts of firepower and mobility, and aircraft could supply both. Helicopters would overcome the problem of operating against an elusive enemy in difficult country by moving men and material rapidly to engage guerrilla forces wherever they showed themselves. Fire from the sky would destroy that enemy as aircraft acted as mobile artillery.

The helicopter strength deployed in Vietnam was unprecedented. They performed on a larger scale all the tasks outlined in Korea. They ferried troops and equipment around

SIKORSKY SKYCRANE

A Sikorsky CH-54 Tarhe helps build a US Army fire-base in the South Vietnamese jungle. The lack of a conventional closed cargo bay let the CH-54 carry objects of almost any size or shape.



– including heavy artillery hung under Sikorsky Skycranes. They kept firebases deep in hostile country supplied and equipped. They evacuated casualties, carried out low-level reconnaissance, and acted as aerial command posts. But helicopters also took on an unprecedentedly active combat role, attacking the enemy on the ground with gun and rocket fire and allowing troops to ride into battle as an “aerial cavalry.” Mass heliborne operations were an impressive spectacle. Lieutenant General Bernard W. Rogers described one that occurred during Operation Cedar Falls in 1967: “The sight of 60 helicopters flying in formation and zooming into Ben Suc at treetop level was one which none who witnessed will ever forget... In less than one and one-half minutes an entire infantry battalion, some 420 men, was on the ground...”



NAPALM AND PHOSPHORUS

During the Vietnam War the US air forces controversially made extensive use of napalm and phosphorous bombs against enemy guerrillas who were dug into concealed positions.